Put What a New Caregiver Would Need to Know in One Current Packet

Four prompts to capture the routine while it's calm, sort current instructions from old ones, think through who may receive what, and set up a packet that stays fresh.

Where you are

You've been caring for someone for a while and you carry most of it in your head. Nothing is changing, but you've wondered what would happen if you were sick for a week and a stranger had to step in.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have one packet, dated, that a new caregiver could read, with a note on who may see it and when it was last checked.

A one-page packet index: About them, Current instructions and their sources, Retired or unsure, Who may receive this, and Version and review date.

Before you start

- A quiet half hour to describe an ordinary day with the person you care for.
- Any instructions you've been given over time, old and new, in whatever state they're in.
- A rough list of who is involved: family, friends, paid helpers, doctors. You don't need to have it all.

PROMPT 1

Capture the routine while nothing is wrong

WHY THIS MATTERS

The best time to describe how the day works is a day when it works. Trying to remember it from a hospital waiting room is how details get lost.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your description of an ordinary day, as you'd tell it to a friend.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I am the main caregiver for someone and I want to write down their routine while things are calm, so a new caregiver could follow it if I were ever unavailable. Here is an ordinary day as I'd describe it to a friend:

> [PASTE YOUR DESCRIPTION]
>
> Turn this into an About Them page with headings: A TYPICAL DAY, WHAT THEY LIKE, WHAT THEY DISLIKE, WHAT TO DO IF THEY'RE ANXIOUS OR CONFUSED, PEOPLE AND PLACES THAT MATTER, and SMALL THINGS THAT MAKE THE DAY GO WELL. Keep my phrasing. Do not include medications or medical steps; this page is about the person, not treatment. End with five questions about their routine I haven't answered.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The small habits you'd never think to mention but a stranger would need.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Answer the five questions over the next week by paying attention.

PROMPT 2

Sort current instructions from old ones

WHY THIS MATTERS

Over months and years, instructions pile up. The one from two doctors ago sits next to last week's. A new caregiver can't tell them apart, and in a hurry, neither can you.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The instructions you've collected, with whatever you know about who gave each and when.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Over time I've collected care instructions for the person I look after. Some are current, some have been replaced, some I'm unsure about. Here they are, with whatever I know about who gave each one and when:
>
> [PASTE THE INSTRUCTIONS WITH SOURCES AND DATES]
>
> Sort them into three groups: CURRENT (I know who gave it and it still applies), RETIRED (replaced or no longer in use), and UNSURE (unknown source, old date, or possibly conflicting). Show the source and date beside each. For every UNSURE item, write the question I should ask the clinician or professional who would know. Do not tell me which instruction is correct, and do not change the wording of any instruction.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

UNSURE items touching medication. Those go to the pharmacist or doctor first.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make a 'retired' folder and move the RETIRED items there, dated, so they stop circulating.

PROMPT 3

Think through who may receive what

WHY THIS MATTERS

A paid aide, a neighbor who checks in, and a sibling across the country do not all need the same packet. Deciding this now avoids an awkward choice made in a rush.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everyone involved and their roles as you understand them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everyone involved in caring for the person I look after, with their role as I understand it:
>
> [PASTE THE LIST OF PEOPLE AND ROLES]
>
> And here are the kinds of information in the packet I'm building: the About Them page, current care instructions, contacts, and preferences.
>
> Make a grid with people down the side and information types across the top. In each cell write LIKELY NEEDS, PROBABLY NOT, or ASK FIRST, based only on the roles I gave. Then list the questions I need to settle before sharing anything, such as whether the person has said who they want informed and whether any legal authority is involved. Do not tell me what the law allows; I will check that with the right professional.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many cells say ASK FIRST. Permission is a question to answer, not a box to assume.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Talk with the person you care for, where possible, about who they want to have the packet.

PROMPT 4

Set up the packet index

WHY THIS MATTERS

A packet without a date and a version is just a pile of paper with a nicer name. The index is what makes it trustworthy a year from now.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I have put together for a care handoff packet that is not being used yet:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Create a one-page packet index with five headings: ABOUT THEM, CURRENT INSTRUCTIONS AND THEIR SOURCES, RETIRED OR UNSURE, WHO MAY RECEIVE THIS, and VERSION AND REVIEW DATE. Under the last heading, give the packet a version number of 1 and leave the date for me. Add a line at the top stating that no handoff has taken place and the packet must be checked before it is shared. Keep to what I gave you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A dated index where every instruction shows where it came from.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Set a review reminder, and keep the index. The next step below gives it a home.

Build the packet on a real profile.

A packet index tells a caregiver where to look. The care interview gathers the person's whole situation into a Family Care Profile, so the packet grows from one organized record instead of a stack of notes.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›